UTTAR PRADESH

Dua, Salaam or Post-pollpourri?

Ganga-jamuni tehzeeb flowed freely in Bulandshahr on February 3 when Priyanka Gandhi's convoy passed by Akhilesh Yadav and Jayant Chaudhury's *rath* during their respective campaigns in the western UP town. All smiles, the political rivals—Priyanka the Congress general secretary in charge of



ANI

CROSSING PATHS
Akhilesh and Jayant greet Priyanka while campaigning in Bulandshahr

UP, and Akhilesh the chief of Samajwadi Party in alliance with Jayant's Rashtriya Lok Dal—waved at each other and exchanged greetings. The camaraderie extended all the way to social media as Akhilesh posted the picture on Twitter, with the caption, '*Ek dua salaam, tehzeeb ke naam* (a greeting in the name of civility)'. Priyanka returned the favour with another photo, and a salubrious '*Hamari bhi aap ko Ram Ram* (greetings to you too)', tagging both Akhilesh and Jayant.

Political strategists believe there's more than meets the eye in the seemingly casual encounter. Both sides knew about the other's convoy. They stopped because they wanted to. It was a show of Opposition unity, displayed also in the Congress not fielding any candidate in seats Akhilesh and Shivpal are contesting. Whiff of a post-poll partnership? ■



Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

UTTAR PRADESH

LADIES CORNER

Has that Priyanka Gandhi slogan—'*Ladki hoon, lad sakti hoon*'—coloured the electoral scene in UP, in parties beyond the Congress? The numbers may not suggest so by themselves. BJP's four lists are still overwhelmingly male. But the Congress claims the ruling party is quite cognisant, and wary, of woman-centric mobilisation. Party folk see it in the way the BJP has inducted women from other parties: Aparna Yadav from the SP, Aditi Singh from the Congress, Vandana Singh from the BSP. Add to that list Priyanka Maurya, the original poster girl of the slogan. Even if numerically modest, women are a visible factor this time, across parties, and beyond UP.

The SP seems to have taken a leaf out of the GOP playbook. Witness the arrival of Pooja Shukla, the 25-year-old student leader who waved a black flag at Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath after stopping his convoy in 2017 in Lucknow. Her candidacy from Lucknow (North), as SP's youngest candidate this election, is notable for more than one reason. After her dramatic act of protest, for which she was jailed for three weeks under various sections of the IPC, SP founder Mulayam Singh Yadav met her in prison and asked her to join mainstream politics. She joined the party's student wing before the Lok Sabha poll and also participated in the January 2020 anti-CAA protests, when she was booked again. This time, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav provided her legal support. Fast forward to 2022. Pooja Shukla—don't miss the surname—is now the party's young-

GOA

BY GOD OR BY LAW

Once bitten by mass defection, the Goa Congress seems twice shy. At one point, it would parade its candidates before sundry gods to swear unswerving loyalty to the party. Now unsure of their godfearing cred, the party is making its candidates submit affidavits declaring they will stay with the Congress, come hell or the BJP. The Aam Aadmi Party is following suit. If it's a hung assembly, they do not want saffronists

MANDAR DEODHAR

